

1 Thessalonians, Part 1

A 50-minute teaching script for Acts 17:1–10 and 1 Thessalonians 1–3

BEFORE CLASS Write on the board: What makes a church's faith in Christ visible? Have Acts 17:1–10; 1 Thessalonians 1:2–10; 2:1–12; 3:6–13 marked for one reader.

BIG IDEA The gospel creates a faithful community whose changed life becomes a witness even under pressure.

0:00–4:00 | Welcome, prayer, and bridge from Galatians

Good morning. Last week Galatians showed us that Christian freedom is not permission to live for ourselves. Faith expresses itself through love, and the Holy Spirit forms a community that serves, restores, and carries burdens.

Today we meet a congregation where that teaching became visible under pressure. First Thessalonians is one of Paul's earliest letters. It lets us see what the gospel produced in a young church before the believers had years of experience, a building, a large budget, or social respectability.

Look at the board: What makes a church's faith in Christ visible? We will listen for Paul's answer rather than begin with our usual measurements of church success.

Let's pray. Father, make your Word active among us. Give us faith that works, love that labors, and hope that endures. Keep our message and our lives together, and make our church a clear witness to Jesus Christ. Amen.

4:00–7:00 | Locate Thessalonica

Paul, Silas, and their companions reached Thessalonica during the second missionary journey after being beaten and imprisoned in Philippi. They traveled roughly one hundred miles west along the Via Egnatia to the capital of Macedonia, a busy port and an important city on a major Roman road.

Only some of us may have finished all three chapters, so here is the setting. The gospel took root quickly. Opposition forced Paul and Silas to leave. Paul worried about the new believers, sent Timothy back, and wrote after Timothy brought an encouraging report of their faith and love.

7:00–11:00 | Read and teach Acts 17:1–10

Ask one reader to read Acts 17:1–10. Ask everyone to notice Paul's message, the people who respond, and the form opposition takes.

For three Sabbaths Paul reasoned in the synagogue from the Scriptures. He explained that the Messiah had to suffer and rise from the dead, and he announced, "This Jesus I am proclaiming to you is the Messiah." As in Damascus and Cyprus, Paul began among his fellow Jews and with Gentiles already drawn to Israel's God.

Three Sabbaths tells us how long Luke highlights Paul's synagogue reasoning. It does not necessarily tell us the total length of the stay. Paul later reminds the church that he worked night and day, and Philippians says that believers in Philippi sent help more than once. We can leave the exact duration open.

Some Jews believed, along with many God-fearing Greeks and prominent women. Other Jewish opponents recruited troublemakers from the marketplace, formed a mob, and attacked Jason's house. Their accusation had political force: "They are all defying Caesar's decrees, saying that there is another king, one called Jesus."

The gospel challenged every ultimate allegiance. Jesus is not one more private spiritual interest. He is the risen Messiah and King. Jason and the new believers discovered immediately that confessing him could carry public cost.

11:00–14:00 | Read 1 Thessalonians 1:2–10

Ask the reader to read 1 Thessalonians 1:2–10. Ask the class to listen for what Paul thanks God for and for the verbs that describe conversion.

14:00–18:00 | Faith, love, and hope become visible

Paul remembers their "work produced by faith," their "labor prompted by love," and their "endurance inspired by hope in our Lord Jesus Christ." These works do not purchase God's acceptance. They show that the gospel has taken root.

Return to the board question. Paul does not begin with their building, finances, attendance, programs, reputation, politics, or social standing. He sees faith working, love laboring, and hope enduring. A church's faith becomes visible in what its members trust, whom they serve, what they endure, and where they place their hope.

Paul says they are loved and chosen by God. How does he recognize that? The gospel came not simply with words but with power, the Holy Spirit, and deep conviction. The messengers' lives supported the message, and the hearers imitated their faithfulness despite suffering.

18:00–23:00 | Receive, imitate, model, resound

Trace the movement in verses 6–8. They received the message amid severe suffering and with joy from the Holy Spirit. They imitated the apostles and the Lord. They became a model to other believers. Then the Lord's message rang out from them.

The verb translated “rang out” appears only here in the New Testament. It means to sound forth, echo, or resound. Paul pictures the gospel carrying outward, almost like a great sound rolling across a landscape. Their witness was not a publicity campaign. People heard the Lord's message and saw the change it had made.

Verses 9–10 describe conversion with three verbs: turn, serve, and wait. They turned from idols to God, served the living and true God, and waited for his Son from heaven. Waiting for Christ did not make them passive. Hope produced service and endurance in the present.

ASK Which of these marks would people outside our congregation notice most clearly? Which might be hardest to see?

23:00–26:00 | Read 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12

Ask the reader to read 1 Thessalonians 2:1–12. Ask everyone to mark the motives Paul denies and the family images he uses.

26:00–34:00 | The messenger's life supports the message

Traveling teachers and philosophers could seek fees, patrons, praise, or influence. Paul's opponents apparently attacked his motives after he left. Paul answers by appealing to what the Thessalonians themselves witnessed.

His appeal did not come from error, impure motives, trickery, people-pleasing, flattery, concealed greed, or a hunger for human praise. He had been entrusted with the gospel and sought to please the God who tests hearts.

But his answer is more than a list of denials. Paul says the missionaries cared for the church like a nursing mother and dealt with them like a father who encourages, comforts, and urges. They shared “not only the gospel of God but our lives as well.” Gospel ministry is truthful and relational. The message and the messenger's conduct belong together.

Paul reminds them that the missionaries worked night and day so they would not burden anyone. Acts tells us that Paul practiced the trade of tentmaking in Corinth. It is reasonable that he used the same trade here, but First Thessalonians does not name it. Philippians also tells us that the church in Philippi sent support more than once. Paul was willing to work and willing to receive faithful partnership; he refused to exploit converts as customers.

ASK How can a teacher's or church leader's conduct either make the gospel more credible or create an obstacle to hearing it?

34:00–37:00 | The Word at work in suffering

Summarize 2:13–16: The Thessalonians received the apostolic message as God's Word, and Paul says that Word was at work in those who believed. Their suffering connected them with the churches in Judea that had also suffered for Christ.

A necessary caution: Paul is speaking about particular persecutors, not condemning Jewish people as a whole. Paul was Jewish. Jesus and the apostles were Jewish. The churches in Judea were Jewish. This passage must never be used to support hostility toward Jews.

37:00–41:00 | Blocked, but not silenced

Paul says he felt “orphaned” from them and made intense efforts to return, “but Satan blocked our way.” The verb can picture a road being cut into or obstructed. Paul saw more than ordinary inconvenience; he recognized spiritual opposition. Yet he does not tell us the earthly mechanism, so we should not invent one.

Read 1 Thessalonians 3:6–10. When Paul could not go, he sent Timothy to strengthen and encourage them. Timothy returned with good news of their faith and love. Paul was relieved: “For now we really live, since you are standing firm in the Lord.” Yet he still prayed to supply what was lacking in their faith. This was a faithful young church, not a finished church.

Satan blocked Paul's road, but he did not silence the gospel. Paul sent Timothy, prayed continually, and wrote a letter that is still strengthening churches two thousand years later.

41:00–45:00 | Read and teach 1 Thessalonians 3:11–13

Ask the reader to read 3:11–13. Paul's response to the report is prayer. He asks God to clear the way for a return, make their love increase and overflow, and strengthen their hearts so that they will be blameless and holy when Jesus comes. That prayer gathers the letter's first half. Paul wants the road reopened, but he wants more than reunion. He wants a congregation growing in love, strengthened in holiness, and oriented toward Christ's return. The future hope we will study next week is already shaping present life.

45:00–48:00 | The Gospel Then and Now

Return to the board: What makes a church's faith in Christ visible?

In Thessalonica, the church had little time, little security, and little social approval. Yet the gospel produced faith, love, hope, changed allegiance, credible ministry, perseverance, and a witness that traveled beyond the city.

Churches now can mistake facilities, finances, attendance, reputation, programs, comfort, politics, or preferred demographics for spiritual health. Those things may be gifts, but none proves that our faith is in Christ. A gospel-shaped church receives God's Word, serves in love, endures in hope, tests its leaders' motives, and lets the message resound through its common life.

DISCUSS Which common sign of church success is easiest for us to confuse with visible faithfulness to Christ?

If time remains: What would it mean for the Lord's message to ring out from our congregation?

48:00–50:00 | Summary, next reading, and prayer

The gospel did not merely survive in Thessalonica. It took root under pressure, reshaped allegiance, and turned a young church into a witness. Their faith worked, their love labored, and their hope endured because God's Word was at work among them through the Holy Spirit.

Before next week, start with 1 Thessalonians 4:1–18 and 5:1–11. If possible, finish chapter 5. Notice how believers live, grieve, wait, and encourage one another in hope.

Let's pray. Father, thank you for bringing the gospel to us in power and by your Spirit. Make our faith active, our love costly, and our hope steady. Guard the integrity of our witness. Strengthen believers who suffer, clear the way for faithful ministry, and make the word of the Lord resound from this congregation. Through Jesus Christ our risen King, amen.

FINAL LINE The gospel makes faith visible in a church that works from faith, labors from love, endures in hope, and bears witness to Christ under pressure.